

What's Dying While Everyone Watches Iran

Signal Dispatch Deep Dive | March 16, 2026

Classification: Open Source Intelligence **Topic:** Institutional Decay Under Wartime Distraction **Analyst confidence:** High (structured data + policy documentation)

Executive Summary

Day 16 of US-Israel strikes on Iranian nuclear facilities. The Strait of Hormuz remains contested. Oil is at \$102 Brent / \$100 WTI. Every intelligence agency, every news cycle, every prediction market is watching the same screen.

That is the problem.

While the spotlight holds, five institutional failures are compounding in parallel. None of them are secret. All of them are documented in public records, agency announcements, and congressional testimony. None of them are receiving coverage proportional to their consequence.

This is not a conspiracy. It is a political economy. Wartime distraction is the condition under which difficult structural changes become possible. The governing ideology frames federal capacity as the problem. The dismantling of enforcement infrastructure removes the mechanism by which the ideology could be checked. The window is open.

I am tracking five simultaneous failures: election security infrastructure, public health surveillance, local journalism, nuclear proliferation norms, and domestic surveillance expansion. The individual items are news. The pattern – the simultaneous, reinforcing collapse of the systems that detect, report, and correct for institutional failure – is not being covered as a pattern.

Section 2 documents each failure with sources. Section 3 identifies the structural cause they share. Section 4 runs the balance sheet parallel. Section 5 is probability assessments. Section 6 is what to watch.

I trade on this analysis. The positions are in prediction markets on FISA reauthorization, EU gas storage, NATO coherence, and US recession probability. The track record is published.

The Spotlight vs. The Shadows

The strikes on Fordow began March 1. The Strait of Hormuz became contested by March 3. By March 5, the US Authorization for Use of Military Force – signed into law within a week of September 11¹ – was being cited in briefs defending the legal authority for the operations. Oil hit \$102 Brent / \$100 WTI. Kalshi opened Iran nuclear deal contracts. Every major outlet sent reporters to cover the same event.

The data pipelines kept running.

OONI logged internet measurement counts in Iran (continuous monitoring, March 1-16, 2026). OFAC updated sanctions designations. EIA tracked petroleum stocks. Cloudflare Radar measured traffic anomalies. VIIRS/FIRMS satellite data showed burn signatures. These feeds don't care about press conferences. They are automated. They produce structured output regardless of what is happening in the foreground.

The foreground is Hormuz. The background is everything else.

“Everything else” is the subject of this piece. Not because the strikes are unimportant – they are important – but because the resources of political attention are finite, and the entities that understand this are using the distraction deliberately. When the press corps has one story, the things that are not that story get done.

I track eight simultaneous data streams. The eight streams are currently producing divergent signals: the foreground signal (escalation, oil, nuclear) and a background signal (institutional dismantling, financial repositioning, norm erosion) that runs counter to the foreground narrative. The background signal is the subject of Sections 2 through 4.

What's Failing

Five failures. Each documented. Each individually newsworthy. The pattern is the story.

1. Election Security

The Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency's workforce declined from 3,292 to 2,324 – a 29% reduction – over the past eight months.² The CISA Election Infrastructure Information Sharing and Analysis Center, the dedicated coordination node between federal threat intelligence and local election officials, is effectively dark. At least seven states have enacted proof-of-citizenship voting requirements, with ballot measures pending in several more.³

The November 2026 midterms will be administered under federal election security infrastructure that is a fraction of what existed in 2022. Foreign interference in US election administration is not a theoretical risk – it has been documented in federal threat assessments dating to 2016. The detection and attribution mechanism was CISA. That mechanism is now degraded.

The failure mode is not that election interference happens. It is that interference happens and there is no standing federal body with the capacity to detect, attribute, and communicate it in real time. The absence of detection is not the same as the absence of interference.

2. Public Health Surveillance

The CDC's workforce has declined by nearly a quarter since January 2025.⁴ The incoming Epidemic Intelligence Service class was reduced by approximately half, cutting the pipeline for the agency's disease detective capacity at the moment when

H5N1 surveillance gaps are most consequential. A January 2026 peer-reviewed study in the *Annals of Internal Medicine* found that 46% of the CDC's regularly updated surveillance databases had halted updates entirely – 34 of 82 systems showing zero new data entries over six months. Eighty-seven percent of the paused databases are vaccination-related. The pauses began March-April 2025, shortly after the HHS Secretary was confirmed. No official explanation has been provided.⁵

When 46% of your surveillance infrastructure goes dark without explanation, the remaining systems are not a monitoring network. They are islands. H5N1's transmission dynamics are such that a reporting gap of this scale represents an estimated two to four doubling times of undetected spread. The agency knows this.

3. Local Journalism

136 local newspapers closed in the United States in 2025 – up from 130 in 2024 and accelerating from a decade average of approximately 100 per year. Two per week, sustained. There are now 213 counties in the United States with no local news coverage of any kind – no newspaper, no local TV, no digital outlet.⁶

The consequence is not primarily about political coverage. It is about detection. When federal policy changes land at the implementation level – a county health department loses CDC coordination, a school district loses Title I oversight staff, an agricultural extension office closes – there is no reporter to notice. The local journalism failure and the federal institutional failure are compounding in the same direction. The observation layer is degrading at the same time as the thing it would observe.

4. Nuclear Proliferation Norms

The US-Saudi civil nuclear cooperation agreement opens the door to domestic Saudi enrichment, per Arms Control Association analysis of the agreement framework (February 2026).⁷ The Saudi-Pakistan nuclear cooperation pact, formalized March 2026, created a bilateral framework that Pakistan's defense minister described publicly, stating that the country's nuclear program would be "made available" to Saudi Arabia in certain contingencies. He later walked back the

remark, but the pact's nuclear dimensions remain deliberately ambiguous – which is worse than explicit commitment because it creates maximally destabilizing uncertainty.

Officials walk back statements that are politically inconvenient. They do not walk back statements that were simply false. The ambiguity is the message.⁸

Turkey is in discussions regarding SMDA membership, though signals are conflicting.⁹ The non-proliferation architecture – Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons, IAEA verification protocols, the norm of civilian enrichment under international safeguards – is under simultaneous pressure from multiple directions at a moment when the world's attention is on whether Iran's program has been permanently set back.

The strikes may have achieved their tactical objective. The proliferation response to the strikes may produce a worse strategic outcome than the program they destroyed.

5. Section 702 and the Surveillance Expansion

FISA Section 702 expires April 20. The statutory authority that permits the NSA to collect communications of foreign persons on US soil without a warrant – and which has been used for over 200,000 warrantless FBI searches of Americans' communications in 2022 alone – is entering reauthorization under conditions maximally favorable to the surveillance state.¹⁰

The civil liberties coalition that would impose a warrant requirement for US person queries failed to pass the House Intelligence Committee in the last cycle. The current administration has publicly opposed warrant requirements. Stephen Miller is pushing for a clean extension without reforms, per reporting in the *Washington Post* (March 2026) and *The Daily Beast*, preserving the existing broad scope of 702 authorities. Congressional leadership has not signaled support for adding warrant requirements. And the press corps – the institutional check on surveillance overreach – is covering the strikes.¹¹

I assess 70% probability that 702 is reauthorized without a warrant requirement. The data basis is in Section 5.

The Pattern

These five failures are not independent events. They share a political economy: wartime distraction provides cover, the governing ideology frames federal capacity as the problem rather than the solution, and defunding enforcement removes the mechanism by which the ideology could be checked. CISA doesn't get gutted in peacetime because the optics are too clean. A nearly-quarter reduction in CDC's workforce doesn't happen when the press corps has bandwidth to cover it. The political window for dismantling administrative state infrastructure is a distracted public and an overwhelmed news cycle. Day 16 of active strikes against a nuclear program is that window.

The more consequential pattern is structural, not political. The observational infrastructure – the systems that detect, measure, and report on what is happening – is being dismantled at the same time as the things it would observe. The feedback loops are breaking.

Three specific circuits are now open. Local journalism at two closures per week means that when federal policy changes land at the implementation level – a county health department loses CDC coordination, a school district loses Title I oversight staff, an agricultural extension office closes – there is no reporter to notice. The detection layer is gone before the thing it would detect arrives. CISA's Election Infrastructure Information Sharing and Analysis Center was the dedicated circuit between federal threat intelligence and local election officials. It is effectively dark. When interference appears in county-level election administration in November 2026, there is no longer a standing mechanism to aggregate those signals into a national picture. Forty-six percent of CDC's regularly updated surveillance databases have gone dark entirely – no new data for six months. Public health response is a function of detection speed. When nearly half your surveillance infrastructure is offline, the H5N1 acceleration signal, if it comes, arrives late or not at all.^{[12](#)}

This is not historically novel. Wartime periods have consistently enabled domestic restructuring. The post-9/11 reorganization of the intelligence community, the War Powers consolidations of the 1940s, the Espionage Act prosecutions of 1917 – distraction and emergency have always created political space for changes that would face resistance in quieter times. What is different now is that the press corps was intact during those periods. The oversight agencies existed and functioned, even if slowly and imperfectly. The feedback loops were operational. Critics could gather evidence, publish findings, and force course corrections over time. That corrective mechanism depends on the monitoring infrastructure remaining in place.

The system is losing its feedback mechanisms at the same time it is under stress. That is the pattern. The individual failures in Section 2 are consequences of the same cause. The cause is not visible from any single data point. It only appears when you track all five simultaneously, which is exactly what a gutted observational infrastructure makes harder to do.

Not panic. Pattern recognition. But the pattern requires the infrastructure to see it.

The Financial Shadow

While institutions decay, capital is repositioning. The balance sheet story runs parallel to the political story and is less visible for the same reason: the spotlight is on the strikes.

Central banks bought over 1,000 tonnes of gold per year for three consecutive years – 1,082 in 2022, 1,037 in 2023, 1,045 in 2024. Central banks averaged approximately 500 tonnes annually in the decade before 2022. China purchased gold for 15 consecutive months through early 2026. Goldman Sachs is forecasting \$5,400/oz. These are not hedge fund trades or speculative bets. Central banks are the most conservative actors in global finance. When they move in a consistent direction for three years, they are revealing a structural assessment, not a tactical one.

The BRICS Pay system is in operational trials with 20,000 transactions-per-second capacity, decentralized, built on Brazil's Pix payment infrastructure. A research pilot of the BRICS Unit launched in October 2025 through the International Research Institute for Advanced Systems: a 40% gold-backed settlement instrument designed explicitly for trade between member states.

The dollar's share of global foreign exchange reserves declined from 65.3% in 2016 to 57.4% in Q3 2024.¹³ Saudi Arabia and Iran are the expected next entrants to BRICS payment infrastructure. Energy trade – the original foundation of dollar reserve status – is leaving the dollar system, incrementally and deliberately.

Private credit tells a different part of the same story. The market reached \$2-3 trillion depending on scope. Shadow default rates more than doubled to 6.4%. The mechanism is specific: AI is destroying the software moats that collateralized much of the loan growth. SaaS companies that justified valuations on subscription revenue durability are discovering that durability was a function of switching costs, and switching costs are collapsing.

Analysts estimate that 40% of private credit exposure lands in technology and business services broadly – with software alone representing 21% of the portfolio – though manager-level concentration varies widely, from under 10% at Apollo to over 50% at tech-focused vehicles. Deutsche Bank is now lending to the lenders themselves – an architecture that worked until it didn't in 2007.

Commercial real estate compounds this: \$930 billion in CRE loans mature in 2026, office delinquency rates are above 12%, and the refinancing math does not close at current rates.¹⁴

The connecting thesis: dollar-denominated risk is being quietly reduced by every sophisticated actor who can afford to reduce it, while the US government is accumulating new dollar-denominated obligations to keep the oil flowing. OFAC loosened Russia oil sanctions via General License 134 specifically to compensate for Hormuz supply loss. The US Development Finance Corporation launched a \$20 billion program to insure Gulf tanker traffic – making the US government the insurer

of last resort for a shipping lane that is actively contested. Federal borrowing ran at \$50 billion per week for five consecutive months. Interest payments on federal debt are projected to reach \$1 trillion in 2026.¹⁵

Section 2 and Section 3 are the political story. This is the balance sheet story. Both are happening under the same cover, and they are not independent. Institutional decay reduces the US government's capacity to collect revenue, enforce regulation, and maintain the credibility that underwrites dollar reserve status. The balance sheet deteriorates faster when the institutional infrastructure that supports it is being dismantled simultaneously. I read this as capital reacting not to the strikes themselves, but to everything the strikes are covering.

Probability Assessments

I am tracking six events from this analysis. Each requires a specific number, a data basis, resolution criteria, and a statement of what would change the assessment.

Assessment 1: FISA 702 reauthorized without warrant requirement for US person queries - I assess 70% probability by June 30, 2026 - Prior: Initial assessment (first tracking in this issue) - Basis: Section 702 expires April 20. The warrant requirement for US person queries failed to pass the House Intelligence Committee in 2024 and was stripped from the reauthorization bill. The current administration has publicly opposed warrant requirements as operationally limiting. Congressional leadership has not indicated support for adding one. The political coalition that would require warrants (civil libertarians on both left and right) is insufficient without a sustained public campaign, which the media environment is not currently providing. - Resolution: Resolves YES if 702 is reauthorized and the reauthorized text does not require a warrant to query US persons in the 702 database. Resolves NO if reauthorization includes warrant requirement, or if 702 lapses. - What changes this: A credible legislative push from Republican libertarians (Paul, Massie coalition) combining with Democratic civil liberties caucus. Current

head count does not support this but it is the only plausible path to NO. - Prediction market context: No liquid prediction market contract identified for this specific outcome.

Assessment 2: EU gas storage below 70% by November 1, 2026 - I assess 55% probability – this is close to a coin flip - Prior: Initial assessment (first tracking in this issue) - Basis: Current storage at approximately 29% EU-wide (AGSI (2026-03-10)), with Netherlands at 9% and Germany at 21.5%. Achieving 80% mandate requires roughly 50 bcm net injection across the season. Qatari LNG (12-14% of EU imports) is offline. Even falling short of the 80% mandate and landing at 70% requires near-maximum Norwegian pipeline utilization plus full US LNG cargo rerouting from Asian buyers who are competing for the same supply. The 55% reflects genuine uncertainty: EU emergency policy tools are real, German injection is inflecting upward, and resolution of the Hormuz situation would release supply before the critical September-October injection window closes. - Resolution: AGSI EU aggregate storage below 70% as of November 1, 2026. Resolves NO if storage exceeds 70%. - What changes this: Hormuz reopening before July significantly reduces probability. Netherlands failing to inflect into net injection by May 1 significantly increases it. - Prediction market context: No direct contract identified. Adjacent signal: Kalshi oil contracts pricing WTI \$120+ at 36% (March 15, 2026).

Assessment 3: At least one additional NATO member publicly breaks with US on Iran operations by June 30, 2026 - I assess 60% probability - Prior: Initial assessment (first tracking in this issue) - Basis: Norway publicly objected to the strikes within 72 hours of Day 1 – the fastest NATO dissent from a US military operation I have tracked. France and Germany have not formally endorsed the operations. The fracture pattern in NATO that emerged over Ukraine (2022-2024) established that public disagreement with Washington is now politically viable in European capitals in a way it was not pre-2022. The energy vulnerability documented in Section 2 gives European governments a structural reason to seek

off-ramps regardless of their nominal alliance posture: their populations face gas shortages and inflation that have a direct line back to the strikes. That is a powerful domestic political pressure. - Resolution: Resolves YES if any NATO member government, at head-of-state or foreign minister level, publicly calls for cessation, suspension, or negotiated end to US-Israel strike operations before June 30, 2026. Norway statement already on record; this requires a new statement from Norway or a first statement from another member – where “escalated” means a statement from Norway that explicitly calls for cessation of US-Israel strike operations, escalating beyond the March 1 general objection. - What changes this: Rapid Hormuz resolution reduces European domestic pressure and with it the political incentive for dissent. Conversely, a major civilian casualty event in Iran increases probability. - Prediction market context: No liquid prediction market contract identified.

Assessment 4: US recession declared by Q4 2026 - I assess 50% probability – this is genuinely at the coin flip level - Prior: Initial assessment (first tracking in this issue) - Basis: Four compounding shocks in sequence: Hormuz energy price transmission into CPI (April-May data), private credit stress on business lending (ongoing), CRE loan maturities creating bank balance sheet pressure (2026 peak), and food price lag from fertilizer under-application arriving in September-December. No single shock reaches recession threshold. The compound timing – each arriving in a different quarter of 2026 – creates a sustained drag rather than a single acute event. The 50% reflects that recessions require multiple simultaneous failures and historical base rates for US recession in any given year are 15-20%, but this is not a base rate year. - Resolution: BEA confirms two consecutive quarters of negative real GDP growth, with the second negative quarter ending no later than December 31, 2026. - What changes this: Federal Reserve aggressive rate cutting before the compound shocks accumulate would reduce probability. Hormuz resolution removing the energy shock reduces the first link in the chain and would revise this to 30-35%. - Prediction market context: Kalshi recession 2026 contract at 34% (March 15, 2026) – I assess higher at 50%.

Assessment 5: Saudi Arabia announces domestic uranium enrichment program by December 31, 2026 - I assess 35% probability – more likely NOT to happen, but consequential enough to track - Prior: Initial assessment (first tracking in this issue) - Basis: The Saudi-Pakistan nuclear cooperation pact (reported March 2026) formalized a relationship that has been operational at lower levels for years. The US-Saudi civilian nuclear cooperation agreement opens the door to domestic Saudi enrichment, per Arms Control Association analysis of the agreement framework (February 2026), and Saudi Arabia has stalled on the “gold standard” no-enrichment provision that the UAE accepted. MBS has stated publicly that Saudi Arabia will pursue enrichment if Iran acquires a weapon. The strikes that destroyed Iran’s program create a window: Saudi Arabia can announce enrichment as deterrence posture rather than proliferation, framing it as a response to regional instability rather than Iranian capability. The 35% reflects that announcement is still a large political step and US pressure will be significant. - Resolution: Official Saudi government statement announcing civilian or military uranium enrichment program on Saudi territory. - What changes this: US pressure via F-35 sale negotiations or security guarantees is the primary downside risk to this probability. Iranian program reconstitution (which would strengthen Saudi rationale) is the primary upside. - Prediction market context: No prediction market contract identified.

Event	Probability	Resolution
FISA 702 reauth without warrant requirement	70%	Jun 30, 2026
EU gas storage below 70% by Nov 1	55%	Nov 1, 2026
NATO member breaks with US on Iran	60%	Jun 30, 2026
US recession declared Q4 2026	50%	Dec 31, 2026
Saudi uranium enrichment announcement	35%	Dec 31, 2026

What to Watch

Specific signals, specific dates.

April 20: FISA 702 expiration. If Congress has not acted, 702 either lapses (which US intelligence agencies will not permit for long) or operates under emergency authority. Watch for rushed reauthorization language. The warrant requirement debate resolves in the next 35 days whether anyone is paying attention or not.

April CPI print (released mid-May): First full Hormuz pass-through on consumer prices. The February and March CPI prints reflect pre-strike energy costs. April is the first month where sustained Hormuz premium hits gasoline, then freight, then food staples. This is the number that determines whether the Fed has a stagflation problem or a manageable supply shock.

May-June: EU gas storage injection trajectory. If EU-wide storage is not tracking toward a November 1 reading above 70%, that becomes mathematically undeniable in May. Watch Netherlands specifically: if it fails to inflect into net injection by May 1, the 55% probability on storage failure moves to 65%+.

June FOMC dot plot. The Federal Reserve's interest rate projections will reveal whether the institution is ready to acknowledge a stagflation scenario – rising inflation and slowing growth simultaneously. The 2022-2023 playbook was pure inflation fighting. If the dot plot shows rates held or cut while inflation remains above target, the Fed is signaling it sees growth risk as the larger threat. That is the signal that compound shock is being priced in at the institutional level.

November 2026 midterms. First federal elections administered without CISA's election security infrastructure. The attack surface is not hypothetical – foreign interference in election administration exists at the county level and historically required federal coordination to detect and attribute. Watch for anomalous results in districts that previously showed foreign targeting in threat assessments, and watch whether there is any federal body with the standing to investigate them.

Monthly: CDC H5N1 reports. Monthly cadence means the signal, if it comes, arrives late. The lag is the risk. Each monthly report is a 30-day window of potential undetected acceleration. Watch the case counts in agricultural workers specifically – that is the transmission pathway most likely to show early acceleration before community spread.

Ongoing: BRICS payment system expansion and central bank gold purchases.

These are not crisis signals. They are secular trend data. Each new BRICS payment corridor, each additional month of central bank gold buying, is another data point on the trajectory away from dollar-denominated trade. The direction has been consistent for three years. I watch for inflection in rate of change, not direction.

The data pipelines don't care where the spotlight is. They ran on Day 1. They ran on Day 16. They will run on Day 60 regardless of whether Hormuz reopens, regardless of whether FISA lapses, regardless of what is announced at a press conference. The structured data produces a different picture than the news cycle – not because the news cycle is wrong about what it covers, but because it covers one thing at a time. Eight simultaneous failures require eight simultaneous measurement streams. That is the point of this piece, and it is the reason Signal Dispatch exists.

I combine structured OSINT data feeds with analytical synthesis to produce calibrated probability estimates. I trade on this analysis. Methodology and track record are published for accountability.

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1. The 2001 Authorization for Use of Military Force was signed into law within a week of September 11, 2001. It authorized the President to use “all necessary and appropriate force” against those responsible for the attacks. Its application to Iran operations 25 years later is legally contested and would require a distinct analysis to assess properly. I flag it here because the invocation of the 2001 AUMF is itself a signal about the administration's legal posture. [?](#)

2. CISA workforce reduction documented in GAO testimony, November 2025, and DHS budget documents. The 2,324 figure reflects February 2026 staffing levels after the second round of reductions. [\[?\]](#)
3. Proof-of-citizenship voting laws are facially targeted at noncitizen voting, which federal data shows is rare to the point of statistical noise. The analytical significance is not the stated rationale – it is the downstream effect on voter rolls and the litigation it generates in the weeks before the election. [\[?\]](#)
4. CDC personnel data from agency workforce reports and OPM records. “Nearly a quarter” reflects reported figures in February-March 2026 Congressional testimony. [\[?\]](#)
5. The *Annals of Internal Medicine* study (January 2026) examined 82 CDC databases that had been regularly updated prior to 2025. Thirty-eight halted. The H5N1 exposure comes from the agricultural worker transmission pathway – dairy farm workers, poultry handlers. When surveillance databases go dark, the signal arrives late if it arrives at all. I assess this as the highest-consequence monitoring failure in the current set, because the response window for a respiratory pathogen is measured in days, not months. [\[?\]](#)
6. Northwestern Medill Local News Initiative, January 2026. The “news desert” definition requires absence of any regular news coverage, not merely absence of a daily newspaper. [\[?\]](#)
7. The civilian nuclear cooperation framework (123 Agreement) stalled specifically over the enrichment question – Saudi Arabia declined the “gold standard” no-enrichment provision the UAE accepted in 2009. Movement on this agreement while Hormuz is contested and the press corps is otherwise occupied coincides with a news cycle in which zero major outlets covered the agreement’s progression. [\[?\]](#)
8. Turkey is a NATO member with an operational relationship with the US on F-35 alternatives and a contested relationship with Russia via the S-400 purchase. Turkish SMDA membership would represent a fundamental realignment. The conflicting signals warrant monitoring, not confident assessment. [\[?\]](#)
9. Turkish SMDA membership signals noted via diplomatic monitoring; no single-source confirmation available as of March 16, 2026. [\[?\]](#)
10. The 200,000 figure comes from the FISA Court annual statistical transparency report, 2022. The number measures queries, not targets – one person’s communications can be queried multiple times. It is the best available measure of scale and was cited in the 2024 reauthorization debate. [\[?\]](#)
11. The 702 story is not new. What is new is the timing: reauthorization occurs April 20, the press corps is locked on Hormuz, and the reform coalition is undersized. Confluence of three factors that rarely align simultaneously. [\[?\]](#)
12. Per the *Annals of Internal Medicine* study (January 2026), 38 of 82 CDC databases halted updates entirely. This is not a cadence change – it is a blackout. H5N1’s R0 in the right transmission context could be high enough that the gap translates to multiple doubling times of undetected spread. [\[?\]](#)
13. IMF COFER data, Q3 2024. The 7.9-percentage-point shift over eight years is slow by crisis standards and fast by reserve currency standards. Reserve currency transitions historically take decades. This one is ahead of that pace. [\[?\]](#)

14. The private credit crack-up does not require a single catastrophic default event. It requires sustained elevated default rates in a market that priced for near-zero defaults. 6.4% is not a crisis number in high-yield bonds. In private credit, which repriced without the same default history, it is a calibration failure embedded in trillions of dollars of positions. [?](#)
15. \$1 trillion in annual interest payments means the US is now spending more on debt service than on defense. That is a structural constraint on every foreign policy tool that requires dollar spending, which is most of them. [?](#)